



TREVISO ITALY

Luscious Tiramisu in the Veneto

The deliciously creamy coffee and chocolate taste of tiramisu puts it high on any list of sweet indulgences. Yet this rich and regal dessert had its origins not in a Renaissance court, but in a family-run restaurant in Italy's Veneto region, an often overlooked part of the country that delivers exquisite food, wine, and cultural experience in equal measures.



While many hurry through the Veneto on their way to Venice, few stop to sample the delights of this historic region. The relative lack of visitors only adds to the appeal of its small towns and cities, such as Verona, the setting for *Romeo and Juliet*, Vicenza, a UNESCO World Heritage site for its outstanding Palladian buildings, and Treviso, which makes a charming base for exploration.

Pretty and prosperous, Treviso has authentic Italian charm within its impressive city walls and gateways. Its porticoed main square, Piazza dei Signori, comes to life every evening when locals meet to exchange news and indulge in the ritual of apéritif-taking in the shade of an elegant medieval *palazzo* with a majestic external flight of stairs.

The peaceful heart of the old town is a maze of narrow alleyways crammed with tiny wine bars serving sparkling local Prosecco. As in Venice, albeit on a smaller scale, water is a big theme. Pretty shaded canals, lined with willow trees and parks, thread through the town – artificial offshoots of the Sile River that rises at a spring on the outskirts before flowing

southeast through to the Venice lagoon. Despite its apparent charms, Treviso is no chocolate-box town; it has moved with the times, becoming one of Italy's leading fashion centers – labels such as Benetton and Sisley are based here – making it a great place to refresh your wardrobe.

Treviso's famous tiramisu is also a recent innovation. It was developed in the kitchens of the town's Ristorante Beccherie (see facing page) in 1962 from *sbatudin* – a pick-me-up for nursing mothers that comprised egg beaten with sugar accompanied by coffee and *savoiardi* – light-as-air sponge finger biscuits. With the addition of creamy mascarpone and powdered cocoa, the dish gradually evolved into the tiramisu we all know and love today, complementing the bountiful cuisine of the Trevigiano countryside.

The area's trademark *radicchio rosso* (red chicory) is also a constant on most restaurant menus, as a delicious wine-red salad, as pâté, or braised and canned. Fresh salad leaves are also served with the traditional *pasta e fagioli* (bean and pasta) soup, an effective twinning of bitter flavor and soft texture that makes for a classic lunch in the Veneto.



Above Grapes are grown for the Veneto's celebratory drink, Prosecco, in vineyards north of Treviso, where the gentle hills provide a perfect microclimate

Prosecco Wine

Grown in the Veneto, in the gentle sun-blessed hills around Treviso, Prosecco grapes are used to make the eponymous light white wine. The wine continues to ferment when bottled, producing tiny bubbles that give Prosecco its characteristic sparkle, giggling their way to the surface when the wine is poured. Unlike *spumante* dessert wines, Prosecco is invariably dry and has been dubbed "Italian champagne." It can be enjoyed on its own, to accompany a dessert, or mixed with fresh peach purée to make a refreshing Bellini cocktail. It is also widely found in the hugely popular Spritz apéritif consumed of an evening in every piazza of the Veneto. Here it is combined with a bright orange or red mixer – either Campari, Select, or Aperol – and soda, lemon, and a juicy fat green olive.

Three Days in the Veneto

Treviso itself is well worth exploring and is a fine base for trips to Venice and other towns of the Veneto, and for touring the gentle surrounding countryside.

DAY ONE Stroll through the heart of **Treviso** starting at the cobbled **Piazza dei Signori**, passing inviting delicatessens on Via Trevisi, to the **Pescheria**, the town's fish market in the middle of a canal. Adjacent is the atmospheric porticoed walkway, the **Buranelli**. Walk over to the other side of town for the **Cattedrale di San Nicolò** to admire its frescoes, which date back to 1352.

DAY TWO Drive northwest through cultivated countryside to the **Montello hills**, famous for their porcini mushrooms and vineyards around **Venegazzu**. Trattorias scattered through the woods and clearings serve the local specialties.

DAY THREE Take the train to **Venice** to wander the car-less streets, and treat yourself to a cappuccino at a canalside café. Don't miss the mornings-only fresh produce market at **Rialto**, close to the vast stone arch of the eponymous bridge. Afterward take a relaxing ride on a vaporetto along the **Grand Canal** to admire the magnificent line-up of *palazzos*.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Treviso's **Canova Airport**, with flights to and from many European cities, is 3 miles (5 km) from the town; Venice's international **Marco Polo Airport** is 18 miles (30 km) away, and is well connected to Treviso by train and bus.

WHERE TO STAY

B&B Dolce Vita (inexpensive) provides cheery lodgings a short hop from downtown Treviso.

www.dolcevitatreviso.com

Albergo Il Focolare (moderate) is good value in the heart of the town. www.albergoilfocolare.net
Relais Monaco (expensive) is a laid-back country villa with swimming pool and extensive parkland, a short drive out of town. www.relaismonaco.it

TOURIST INFORMATION

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